



Partner in crime: RCB captain Smriti Mandhana is seen discussing tactics with ace all-rounder Ellyse Perry. Mandhana says she is 'happy' Perry is fielding for her side and not others. SPORTZPICS / WPL

continue doing what I love," she affirmed.

Having players like Sophie Devine alongside Perry makes it easier for Mandhana to lead a young and dynamic team, a perspective sometimes overlooked from a leadership standpoint.

"Last year, when the auction happened, I was in two minds about how they (Perry and Devine) were going to adjust to being on your team because we've always played against each other for like eight to 10 years. I don't think we've ever spoken

to each other while playing because we both are, I think, reserved people."

The transition from rivals to teammates running with the same target eventually panned out to be smoother than expected.

"Last year, the campaign didn't go the way we wanted, but the kind of support they gave me... was something nice, and we bonded over that a lot more because sometimes when things are going well, you may not really understand the value, but when things are not going well and

then when we stick together, I think that's what makes these guys special," she added.

"With the experience they had, they kind of had everyone together; they even supported me a lot. This year we started talking from the first day, and it was easy because we kind of know each other now. It's amazing to have them around.

A lot of youngsters in India get inspired by both of them, and I'm happy that she's (Perry) fielding for our side and not for the others," Mandhana chuckled.